

PROMISING RETURN PRACTICES

PRE-RETURN GREECE

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Name of practice	Open Centre for Migrants Registered for Assisted Voluntary Return and Reintegration	
Dates	2015 - present	
Target group	Potential Returnees	
Geographic Scope	Country	Greece
	Regions	Europe
	Sub Region	Mediterranean
Actor	International Organization for Migration Reception and Identification Service (Ministry of Migration and Asylum)	
Return Stages	Pre-Return	
Challenge addressed	Logistics, Places, and Materiality Identification, Detention and Case Management.	
Principles referred (Implicit or explicit)	Human-rights-based approach	

SUMMARY

The Open Centre for Migrants Registered for AVRR (OCAVRR) in Athens has emerged as a notable example of an urban, temporary accommodation facility for migrants registered in the AVRR programme run by IOM Greece. Established in 2015 in collaboration with the Reception and Identification Service of the Ministry of Migration and Asylum, OCAVRR has a capacity of approximately 100 residents. It accommodates vulnerable AVRR participants either throughout the return process or during specific stages. Unlike the prevailing reliance on detention for all RMIs, OCAVRR functions as an open facility, providing social, medical, psycho- educational and recreational services.

BENEFITS/IMPACTS AND SHORTCOMINGS

Between September 2019 and August 2023, the centre hosted 2,482 migrants in total, while the current AVRR programme (September 2023-December 2027) aims to accommodate 1,700 individuals.

OCAVRR, as the most well-organised urban facility for returnees in Greece, stands in sharp contrast to the absence of comparable urban structures dedicated to asylum seekers and beneficiaries of protection. This disparity raises critical concerns regarding the state's priorities, suggesting a greater commitment to ensuring dignified living conditions for those who consent to return to their countries of origin than for those in need of protection and integration into the local society.

KEY LESSONS

Open urban accommodation facilities are essential for a dignified and rights-compliant solution. Contrary to the conditions prevailing in detention facilities and in spatially isolated camp-like accommodation centres, open urban accommodation facilities for returnees can ensure a more dignified process and living conditions during the pre-return phase.

RECOMMENDATIONS

Separate voluntary return programmes from detention. AVRR programmes should opt for genuinely voluntary participation. Individuals already registered in the programme should not be detained and should be offered supportive accommodation instead. In Greece, authorities could ensure this by offering placement at OCAVRR.

Improve reception and accommodation for all migrants. Humane reception conditions should extend beyond returnees to asylum seekers and beneficiaries of protection. Urban facilities that offer safe and dignified living spaces are more effective than isolated camps for supporting well-being and integration. In Greece, OCAVRR serves as a model for such facilities, demonstrating how urban accommodation can provide dignified living spaces for its residents.

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